The Good Shepherd

A cooperative rescue game — Ages 5-8 — 2-4 Players — 15 Minutes

Age Range	Players	Play Time	Difficulty
5-8	**2-4**	**15 minutes**	**Easy**

About This Game

The Good Shepherd is a cooperative game based on Jesus' parable of the lost sheep (Luke 15:3-7). Players work together to help the shepherd find all ten lost sheep and bring them home before nightfall. Everyone wins together — or not at all — just as the shepherd does not rest until every sheep is found.

> **Formation Goal:** Knowing deeply that Jesus loves each one of us and will never stop seeking us.

Components

- **24 Path Cards** — Move cards, Obstacle cards, and Blessing cards
- **1 Board** — Landscape with Hills, Valley, Forest, River, and Sheepfold
- **10 Sheep Tokens** — Cut-out sheep to hide and find (printed on the board sheet)
- **1 Day Tracker** — A simple 6-step sun-to-moon track (printed on the board)

Setup

1. Print the board and cut out the 10 sheep tokens.
2. Place the board in the centre of the table.
3. Shuffle the sheep tokens face-down. Place 2-3 tokens on each of the four locations (Hills, Valley, Forest, River). Leave the Sheepfold empty.
4. Place a marker at the start of the Day Tracker (the sun).
5. Shuffle the 24 Path Cards and place them in a face-down draw pile.

How to Play

1. The youngest player goes first. Play passes to the left.
2. On your turn, draw one Path Card and read it aloud.
3. **Move Cards** (green): Move the shepherd to the named location and flip over one sheep token there. The sheep is found! Move it to the Sheepfold.
4. **Blessing Cards** (blue): A special gift from God! Follow the card instructions — you may find two sheep, or gain extra time.
5. **Obstacle Cards** (red): Something blocks the way! Two players must agree to "work together" (tap the table together or hold hands) to overcome it. If they do, reveal one sheep. If playing with only two players, obstacles are automatically overcome.
6. Some cards move the Day Tracker forward (toward night). If the tracker reaches the moon before all sheep are home, the game is lost.
7. If the draw pile runs out, reshuffle.

Winning

All players win together when all 10 sheep are safe in the Sheepfold! Celebrate together — just like the shepherd called his friends and neighbours to rejoice.

If the Day Tracker reaches the moon before all sheep are found, the shepherd must try again tomorrow. Discuss: "How many sheep did we save? Jesus would keep searching until every one was found."

Tips for Parents and Teachers

- For the very youngest (ages 3-4), reduce to 6 sheep and remove the Day Tracker.
- After the game, ask: "Who is the Good Shepherd in real life? Who are the sheep?"
- Remind children: "Jesus said, 'There is more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine who need no repentance.'"

- Play cooperatively — never competitively. This game has no individual winner by design.

> *"What man of you, having a hundred sheep, if he loses one of them, does not leave the ninety-nine in the wilderness, and go after the one which is lost until he finds it? And when he has found it, he lays it on his shoulders, rejoicing."* — Luke 15:4-5